

GETTY IMAGES

1. *A handloom weaver in Nalgonda, Andhra Pradesh*

2. *A weaver rinsing jute fibre to let it dry under the sun*

3. *An Indian model wearing a handloom-produced garment at the Amazon India Fashion Week Autumn-Winter 2017*



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selves—quite unexpectedly—better-placed than many other sectors of the economy. To what can we attribute this?

One reason is the growing access to the internet. Traditionally, craftspeople had little contact with their urban consumers. Now, thanks to the ubiquitous smartphone, they have direct access to their buyers, as well as Google, Pinterest and websites where they can check out design and product development ideas, in addition to negotiating rates, rather than being entirely dependent on ignorant if not actually exploitative middlemen. They now know the prices at which their products are being sold by others in lifestyle stores. They also have their own Facebook and Instagram pages, have learnt to handle video calls and can promote their work and take orders online. Even an uneducated craftswoman can now recognise a photo of a weave or a colourway.

Rising education levels, too, have helped. From a situation of total dependency a couple of decades ago, craftspeople now have the tools to be entrepreneurs and are in control of their lives. It's wonderful to see handloom products going beyond dingy Khadi emporiums and bureaucratic state corporations.

Even more significant than this digital transformation is their growing awareness of the value of their skills. The heartbreaking trek of migrant workers back to their villages in 2020—jobless, moneyless—made many rural artisans realise that having a unique skill and source of income in their hands, especially one that could be practised independently in their homes with minimum infrastructure, could be a great benefit. Raw materials are relatively cheap and often locally available, and a loom, though capable of delivering broad-ranging,